**Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay**

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

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**Critical Notes on Robert Frost's "A Leaf Treader"**

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of what the speaker in the poem infers he (we) might learn from nature, especially through a comparison involving the life cycle of a leaf include

alliteration,
anaphora,
apostrophe,
characterization,
consonance,
controlling image,
couplet,
end-stopped line,
iamb/iambic,
imagery,
metaphor,
polyptoton,
rhyme scheme,
rhythm,
simile,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

The speaker in Frost's poem points, in line 9, to a similarity between the falling/fallen leaves and the "fugitive in [his] heart," perhaps running from the fact that is death. The young contestant should be able to identify autumn as the poem's controlling image or as a metaphor—as well as the recurring/returning source of threat (line 7) and grief (line 10).

The contestant should recognize that the speaker likens the life cycle of the leaf to his own life. In the final stanza, however, he breaks the comparison, noting that he does not have to accept the "invitation to grief" (line 10): "it was no reason I had to because [the leaves] had to go [to their deaths]." Indeed, the last line of the poem records the speaker's reminding himself (his knee) that the last stages of the leaves' life cycle, while having made him "autumn-tired" (line 1), are not his, at least not this year.

The writer might sense a tone of triumph in that the "fugitive in [his] heart" refuses the "invitation to grief" and that he survives; indeed, his triumphal walk, "safely trodd[ing] under foot the leaves of another year" (line 4), is the walk of a leaf treader.

The student might venture the observation that even the act of considering death, especially in a manner that suggests a recurring victory reflected in the self-absorbed musing, "God knows all the color and forms of leaves I have trodden on and mired," reveals a deep concern about death, a concern inferred in the self-reflective line, "Perhaps I have put forth too much strength and have been fierce from fear" (line 3).

The writer might make something of all of the end-topped lines' contributing to either or both the poem's theme and tone.